

To whom it may concern:

May 2, 2026

It is my pleasure to write this letter of recommendation for Zackery Duhala, whom I supervised as a student teacher from August, 2025-May 2026.

Two major formative experiences influenced Mr. Duhala's decision to pursue a career in education: strong, inspiring science teachers in high school who kindled his interest in science, and sports coaches who helped shape his character. He currently works at the YMCA as a Unit Leader, further reinforcing his desire to work with youth, especially those who lacked a strong support system at home. His goal is to work as a high school biology teacher and coach, particularly in football--where he has much playing experience through college--and lacrosse.

In the classroom, Mr. Duhala demonstrated an excellent command of the "nuts and bolts" of teaching: classroom management procedures such as opening activities, transitions, well-sequenced lessons with efficient use of time, clearly stated class expectations, attention getting signals, different questioning techniques to solicit student engagement, and clearly stated directions and instructions. He engaged students with equal skill, showing a good mix of pedagogical techniques, strategies, and methods, e.g. labs which connect to real life, modeling of concepts, questioning techniques which required critical thinking, and constant circulation during labs/activities to monitor student learning. For example, Mr. Duhala 1) designed a challenging Mammalian Dive Reflex Lab where students had to construct an evidence-based explanation describing how the MDR supports homeostasis, 2) an ocean acidification lesson incorporating pH, and 3) a genetics lesson where students used AI to generate an image of children's traits. His lessons were NGSS aligned, carried out as written, and appropriately rigorous for the class he was teaching. Mr. Duhala developed an easy rapport with his students which facilitated engagement and discussions.

After each lesson Mr. Duhala was very reflective and willing to implement suggestions for improvement, as evidenced by videos demonstrating the improvements.

Beyond the classroom, Mr. Duhala is interested in supporting student-led clubs and programs, particularly in the life sciences. He also would like to build a strong biology elective strand within the existing curriculum.

Zackery Duhala brings to teaching his playing/coaching background, enthusiasm, excellent subject matter knowledge, a wide range of pedagogical strategies, and the flexibility/desire to improve his craft. He will be an outstanding addition to any high school science faculty.

Steve Rodecker
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